cover people over 60 years of age or those over 45 with comorbidities. The prime minister waited his turn for a month and half since the country began vaccinating frontline and healthcare workers, refusing to take the vaccine out of line. Since February, leaders from the Opposition and their ecosystems had begun to question as to why the prime minister had not taken the vaccine when other world leaders were making a beeline in their respective countries to get the shot on priority. The prime minister's stance on this was clear. He had said in his video conference with the chief ministers on 13 January, three days before the vaccine drive began, 'No politician, even by mistake, will not take the vaccine during the first phase because the first right on the vaccine is for frontline and healthcare workers.' Not only has the prime minister shown personal disdain for entitled folks during his tenure, but has also passed several policy decisions which reject the VIP culture—widespread in India. Hence, not allowing politicians to cut the vaccine queue was in line with his demonstrated school of thought. Naturally, as a politician, he would lead by example, and wait his turn for the vaccine too. However, the fact that he was not taking the vaccine was being woven into media stories about how his actions were fuelling vaccine hesitancy and helping the Opposition build up on its questioning the credibility-of-Indian-vaccines narrative. In later months of the vaccine drive, during an interaction with the prime minister, he had said:

> There was no question of me taking the vaccine in January. Equality has been the cornerstone of our vaccination drive. If I would have cut the line as the prime minister of the nation, so many more individuals with privilege would have thought it was ok to do so too and that they'd get away with it. In the truest sense, the fundamental thought behind creating a platform like CoWIN was also to ensure equality—that a technology platform would not discriminate on the basis of rich, poor, class and such other factors and treat all individuals equally in assigning slots for jabs. In fact, for very vulnerable individuals like the handicapped who may have difficulty accessing documents, we created a system where they'd only need their Unique Disability ID to get the vaccine. We even put together an SOP early on for vaccination of folks who don't have any kind of photo ID whatsoever—like nomads, saints, seers, ascetics, inmates, homeless and such groups. I was clear from the very beginning that no discrimination should be done in the process of vaccine